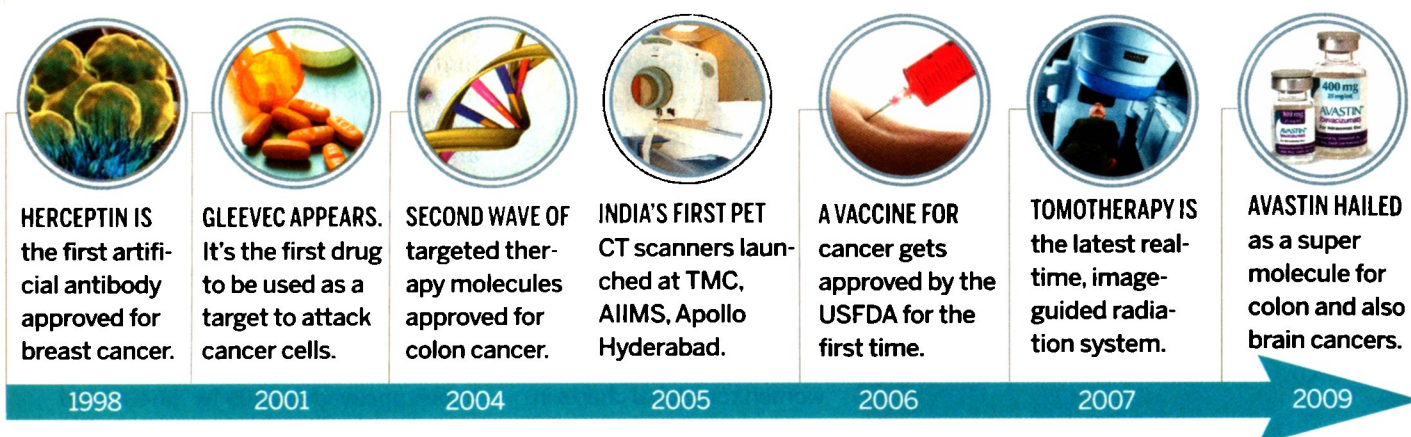


Timeline of New Therapeutics



established that women undergoing breast cancer surgeries during the luteal phase of their menstrual cycle (when the presence of hormone progesterone is more) had higher survival rates and less chances of a recurrence. TMC used this hypothesis on 1,000 women and found a 30 per cent reduction in mortality. "And all at just Rs 65 and no side-effects," says Badwe with a smile.

Cost is really the killer in India. Namita Chauhan, 40, of Delhi credits her recovery from breast cancer to a new molecule drug, Herceptin. "Yes, you do get the new drugs here, but how many can afford it," she asks. She needed 15 doses and had to shell out a prohibitive Rs 1 lakh for each dose. The good news is: the best cen-

tres for cancer in India are believed to be AIIMS in Delhi and TMC in Mumbai, both of which subsidise the rates. The real-time radiation device, Tomotherapy, at TMC—the only such in South Asia—was bought at a cost of Rs 24 crore. TMC charges Rs 2,000 from 80 per cent of those who cannot afford to pay. "But doctors also push up costs," says Reddy. "Many are too eager to recommend high-end drugs and devices to patients, to stay ahead of the competition." The cancer burden might just get lighter when generic drug-makers enter the market with a larger platter of made-in-India "biosimilars".

"We will cure cancer," has been the mantra of scientists for the last five decades—from the rise of mega-

voltage radiotherapy in the '50s to the birth of artificial antibodies in the '90s. There's a new excitement as treatments move toward targeted therapies, super molecules and ever-more high-precision radiation. With exciting new therapeutics in the pipeline, can cancer finally be conquered? "I certainly think so," says Rath with infectious optimism. "When I look back, I am struck by the progress we have made since the time I started my career at AIIMS 36 years ago." One of the senior-most consultants at AIIMS, Rath expects a cure for cancer over the next 15 years ("And certainly within my lifetime").

That brings new hope to people like Subhash Mishra, a 50-something professor at IIT-Guwahati, who was diagnosed with a grade three brain cancer last year. Mishra never agonised over "why me", never went through the yo-yo curve of denial and despair. In fact, as a scientist he "rather enjoyed" being a part of the high-tech world of battling cancer. "I was curious to understand the real-time Trilogy radiation system at TMC," he says. "There was no time to get scared." He went to hospitals alone, always discouraged those who wanted to accompany him. And often took classes before checking in for a chemoradiation session. He knows that cancer kills, but refuses to take it seriously in an era of therapeutic promise: "Yes, I have cancer. So what?"

with Nishika Patel, Stephen David and Priya Verma

NAMITA CHAUHAN 40

BREAST CANCER SURVIVOR

"You are the most beautiful bald lady in the world"—that's what her husband had told her at the height of her cancer trauma. Five years later she is finally facing life with confidence. Yes, she took Herceptin—the original targeted therapy against cancer. "The new drugs might be available but are they affordable," she asks. She had to take 15 doses and each was for a lakh. She still winces at the memory. "The new drugs will make a difference only if they are within the common man's reach," she says.

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